

Isn't This 2007?

In a trial that involved cyber-terrorism, Judge Peter Openshaw told prosecutors at Woolwich Crown Court, London: "I don't really understand what a Web site is." Lawyers tried to explain, but without success: "I haven't quite grasped the concepts." Oh well, it takes all sorts...



No Dithering, Please

Apple is fighting another lawsuit, filed by two California residents. It contests Apple's assertions that Macbooks can display "millions of colours", as those colours are made possible through dithering! Apple claims to display 8 bits per channel—over 16 million colours without dithering



Escape

WIN BY LOSING

The Web As Community

This one illustrates the idea of "Internet Phenomenon." Having read this bit of news, this writer fondly remembers Mahir Cagri, Internet Phenomenon par excellence in 1999. There's a .org devoted to preserving the original Mahir homepage (they were pages then, not blogs), while updating it with photographs of Mahir's new successes with the public at large. However, at www.IKissYou.org, they seem to have omitted the "I like sex," which was one of Mahir's glib statements on his original page.

The page, to keep a long story short, was the Turkish Mahir's attempt at reaching out to people by telling them about himself. The English was atrocious, and that made for about half the appeal of the page—and of Mahir. Essentially, people loved Mahir because of his

seeming innocence, generosity, and child-like frankness. Some of the gems on the page included "I like music, I have many many music enstrumans my home I can play," and "I like to be friendship from different country." Well, that's quite enough of the nostalgia: fast-forward to 2007, and we have Casey Serin, 24, a would-be real estate agent from California, who bought eight houses in eight months in four states with no money as down payment. He managed that through credit—he was hoping to sell the properties for a huge profit. As it came to pass, he lost everything, and ended up owing about \$1,70,000 to his creditors.

Almost bankrupt, Serin launched IAmFacingForeclosure.com to tell the world about his mistakes, to help others learn from his financial mismanagement. Overnight, a community was

formed, the members of which began competing with each other to post the most biting criticism of Serin's failure. That's quite the essence of "Internet Phenomenon."

What is Serin doing now? What follows reads like a mish-mash of a bad dream, so brace yourselves.

Serin has discovered it can be profitable to outrage and annoy thousands of people through his blog every day. He gets around \$1,000 a month through Google ads. His ill-gotten fame has taken him all the way to a couple of talk shows. Serin's creditors are still suing, and there happens to be a set of bloggers who want to see him annihilated.

As had happened with Mahir, Serin has become so famous there's a remix mocking his favourite sayings, doctored photos of his, and a couple of anti-Serin Web sites. A Google search on "casey serin" without the quotes brings up about a third of a million

Whatever Happened To...

Copy-Protection Dongles

A while ago, someone came up with the bright idea of hardware copy protection for software, something like a key. These are called dongles, and look like connectors. They're hardly seen today.

Earlier versions of parallel port dongles looked like connectors and had electronic chips installed. These chips stored data that was used for software encryption and key validation of a program. Dongles evolved; USB hardware dongles cropped up with microprocessors and inbuilt strong encryption by way of cryptographic cipher texts and keys. But—you guessed it—crackers found ways to crack the keys and therefore the software.

Today, you can order software online. Most software available these days need a registration with the user's name and e-mail. Which can, of course, be worked around, to put it gently. One merit dongles had was that they couldn't be downloaded... but there were the demerits: for every application, the copy protection software created a separate key, and one had to enter the key for each application, each time. The keys and ciphers of the dongles could be decrypted, so dongles couldn't survive as trusted client models for legitimate users. Finally, the high cost of dongles was a factor that led to their demise. You'll still see a few lying around here and there, though.

Win! My Desktop

Last month's winner is

Wasim Akram S.N., Chennai

How he did it:

1. Use the "Panther" StyleXP theme
2. Installed Object Dock with "OS-K" icons from kde-look.org
3. Removed unnecessary icons from desktop.
4. Removed system icons using TweakUI
5. Took a screen shot of the desktop and reduced the image to 85% of its size
6. Used that picture as his desktop wallpaper (centered) and repeated the above 9 times.

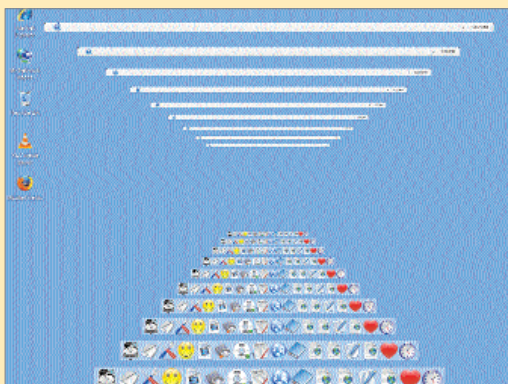
Participate in this contest and win next month

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by Bill Evjen & Kent Sharkey

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Send in your Desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.